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DESERT DELIGHTS

Don't believe the postcards. If you really want to explore Jaisalmer, ditch the camel for a jeep

By **AMIT DIXIT**

Home to the second-oldest fort in Rajasthan, Jaisalmer was founded in 1156 by Rawal Jaisal. It once stood at the crossroads of important trade routes, including the Silk Road. In 2013, this 'living fort' was declared a UNESCO World Heritage Site, grouped under the 'Hill Forts of Rajasthan'. About 40 km from the golden fort lie the shimmering sand dunes of Sam, at the edge of the Thar Desert. This is a different sort of crossroads—where excitement and adventure intersect.

There's no better way to explore the desert than on a 4X4 jeep safari. It is thrilling and more efficient than being on a camel's back. Apart from a healthy dose of off-roading and dune bashing, the safari also takes you to villages lying deep in the barren grandeur of the Thar, where you can interact with locals, observe life and even have a rustic meal rustled up for you.

On longer jeep safaris, a spin around the Desert National Park is added on. Spanning an area of over 3,100 square kilometres, this is one of India's largest national parks (you're not covering it all, but a jeep safari does allow you to cover large swathes). Home to the endangered Great Indian Bustard, you might also sight chinkara and desert foxes, besides an array of birds like partridges, eagles, falcons, kestrels and, in winter, demoiselle cranes and houbara bustards.

If you choose to spend the night under a sparkling desert sky, accompanied by Rajasthani folk dance performances and unabashedly Rajasthani food, you are sure to have the makings of a magical trip. Both sunset and sunrise safaris are on offer, and you can repeat it all at Khuri sand dunes.

Another not-to-be-missed pit stop on your jeep safari is the Gadisar Lake. Built by the aforementioned Rawal Jaisal, it was rebuilt by Gadsi Singh in 1367. The artificial lake, just 1.5 km outside the fort, is lined with exquisite cenotaphs and Hindu shrines. ■



SHUTTERSTOCK

(Top) An aerial view of the Jaisalmer Fort; (bottom) a desert jeep safari vehicle

JAISALMER

The Royalty Awaits

